

Gusuku, Paddy and Runway: Chatan and the Base That Split a Village

On Okinawa's central-west coast, a coral-limestone castle, the island's finest rice paddies and a sixteenth-century sweet potato all mark ground that the US landing of 1 April 1945 remade overnight. An airfield cut the old village in two, bases still cover roughly half the town, and a returned airstrip became the shopping streets of American Village.



北谷・嘉手納（沖縄県）

In this dossier

1. A history of the district (6 chapters, about 1600 words)
2. Timeline
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Written in English from Japanese library sources — chiefly books digitised by the National Diet Library — and official records. Superscript numbers point to the numbered sources at the end, with page frames for the digitised books.

A castle, a monk and a sweet potato

Chatan occupies a stretch of low coral-limestone coast in central Okinawa, and its oldest visible monument sits on a low, tongue-shaped ridge above the shore: Chatan Gusuku, a fortified hilltop about 500 meters long whose five walled enclosures once housed a regional power of the Chuzan kingdom. Japan's Agency for Cultural Affairs, which designated the ruin a national Historic Site in March 2021, dates its main building phase from the late thirteenth to the early sixteenth century and records finds of imported trade ceramics among its cut and roughly coursed limestone walls; the town's own account of the site calls it a connected-compound gusuku of four aligned terraces, among the largest such castles on the island.¹¹¹²

The old district's name is itself a small piece of history. A 1649 map submitted to the shogunate by the Satsuma domain labels the local magiri, or district, with the kana "kitatan", which the town's own history traces sliding over generations through "kichatan" and "chichatan" into today's "Chatan" — "tan", in the dialect of Kagoshima officials who compiled the map, simply meaning valley. A charter is said to mention the name as early as 1577. By the sixteenth century the magiri comprised twelve hamlets strung along the coast and inland, among them Chatan itself, Kuwae, Yara and Noguni, all of which would remain one administrative unit until the twentieth century.⁵

One of those hamlets gave Okinawa a food staple. A history of Ryukyu's "five great men", printed in 1916, credits Noguni Sokan — a title meaning simply "the intendant from Noguni" — with carrying the sweet potato back from China in 1605, during the reign of King Sho Nei; the book itself notes that scholars already argued over whether someone else had beaten him to it, but records that in 1764 the kingdom formally commended his achievement. A generation or so later, Chatan's Tamayose hamlet produced a monk remembered as "the Elder of Chatan": ordained Nan'yo Shoko, he studied in mainland Japan around 1603 and returned, a 1937 guide to Okinawa records, as one of the channels through which mainland Japanese learning reached the Ryukyu court.¹²

The finest rice paddies in the prefecture

For most of its history before 1945, Chatan was known not for castles or monks but for water. The magiri's twelve hamlets became twelve numbered "aza" in 1908, when Okinawa's old magiri were reorganized into villages on the Japanese pattern, and Chatan village prospered as a farming community built around a lowland that three of its hamlets — Chatan, Tamashiro and Dendo — shared: paddies the town's own history calls the "Chatan Tabukwa", ranked among the three finest rice-growing tracts in the whole prefecture. It is a landscape that has almost entirely vanished, and one reason this dossier's aerial photographs are worth studying closely for the traces reclamation and construction have left across the lowland.⁵

Kadena, on the northern edge of the old magiri, grew into Nakagami district's own hub in these decades: Kadena's own history describes it hosting the terminus of the prefectural railway, a prefectural middle school, an agricultural school and a sugar mill, all serving a wide rural hinterland that still belonged, administratively, to Chatan village.⁹

Invasion and a village cut in two

War reached Chatan before the main invasion did. Japan's national record of civilian war dead, compiled by the Ministry of Internal Affairs and Communications, records 33 people killed in Chatan village in the air raid of 10 October 1944, the day US carrier aircraft struck targets across Okinawa. The main invasion followed on 1 April 1945: the Okinawa Prefectural Archives' own chronology puts some 1,400 to 1,500 ships and about 183,000 troops of four US Army and Marine divisions ashore along the coast running through Yomitan, Kadena and Chatan, and records that by nightfall the invaders held both the Japanese airfield at Yomitan and the one inside Chatan's own boundary — the airstrip this dossier's angle on Kadena Air Base begins from — against only light resistance. Within days the surrounding rice paddies and farmland were being cleared for what would grow into that base, and the prefectural archives' own account of the town's occupation describes its residential areas as comprehensively destroyed.⁷¹³¹⁶

The airfield did something no natural disaster had: it cut the village bureaucratically in half. By 1948, expanding US management of the runway had closed off all passage across it, so that residents on the airfield's far side had to travel by way of Naha or central Okinawa simply to reach their own village office. On 4 December 1948, with a population of about 3,800, the northern hamlets separated to form Kadena village — an administrative divorce forced, in effect, by the base itself; Kadena would go on to become Nakagami district's seventh town, in January 1976.⁷⁹

Recovery in what remained of Chatan depended in part on connections built by decades of emigration. Okinawa's prefectural archives record a Hawaii-based relief and rehabilitation society helping the devastated community between 1947 and 1951, years in which contested land claims — farmland whose boundaries and ownership records had been destroyed along with the houses that stood on it — were the subject of public hearings in 1951; the same records note a further wave of emigration from Chatan to Brazil, Peru and Bolivia through the 1950s and 1960s, as base employment only slowly replaced the vanished rice economy.⁷

Two-thirds of a town under fences

When Okinawa reverted to Japanese administration in 1972, US bases still covered about 65 percent of Chatan's land, according to a National Archives of Japan account of the town drawn from its own administrative records; only 11,496 residents were left to live on the remaining third. A similar figure — 68 percent of the town under military use, with base-related work accounting for the great majority of a local economy in which services alone made up 86 percent of output — appears in the town's own retrospective on the era of Mayor Higa, when Chatan drew up its first village promotion plan in 1974, a ten-year program aimed at 1981. Chatan gained formal town status in 1980, still governing a community whose developable land was a minority of its own territory.⁴⁸

Return, when it came, came from the coast. In 1981 the US military gave up Hamby Airfield, a small strip on the western shore, together with the inland May-Moscarella firing range — the two returns the town's own planning report of 2004 calls the point at which "prospects for the town's development opened wide" after decades of being penned in. Even so, as of the town's own 2018 accounting, Kadena Air Base, Camp Kuwae, part of Camp Zukeran and an Army fuel depot together still occupied about 51.6 percent of Chatan's 13.91 square kilometers, leaving 7.2 square kilometers for everything else the town does.³⁶

From Hamby Airfield to American Village

The returns of 1981 gave the town back two modest but well-placed parcels: Hamby Airfield, about 42.5 hectares on the western shore, and the inland May-Moscarella firing range, about 22.9 hectares. Chatan first tried to have the airfield site zoned as resort land, but prefectural planners, judging the island already had enough hotel capacity, blocked the idea; the town instead registered it for housing in 1985, completed fresh landfill along the adjoining shore by 1987, and only later, once the residential base was secured, steered the combined site back toward tourism and commerce. A land-readjustment project turned the old runway into the streets of a new Kitamae district, and Chatan's own 2004 completion report for the project describes Kitamae and the reclaimed Mihama district beside it as a single waterfront redevelopment in all but name.³¹⁴

The town settled on the concept that would define the site — an entertainment and shopping district styled after an American seaside town — in 1992, and construction began in earnest in 1997, with shops and attractions opening in stages from the following year until the complex now known as Mihama American Village was substantially complete by 2004. A Ferris wheel, cinemas, restaurants and beachfront shops now occupy ground that was a US Marine Corps airfield within living memory, on a reclaimed shoreline immediately next to bases that, a few hundred meters inland, still occupy roughly half the town.³⁸

Reading the ground today

Little of pre-war Chatan is visible at street level, which makes Chatan Gusuku's limestone walls worth the climb: unlike the vanished paddies below it, the castle's terraces and one-meter-plus walls survive largely as archaeologists have mapped them, predating by three centuries the airfield that would later reshape everything around it. Fenced perimeters remain the town's most persistent visual fact — Kadena Air Base's boundary, Camp Zukeran's, Camp Kuwae's — and comparing them with the pre-war extent of the old "Chatan Tabukwa" paddies is one of the more direct ways to see how much of the historic farmland this dossier's aerial photographs sit on now lies behind a fence rather than under a plough. The landform record behind this dossier's Basic brief shows much of the coastal strip, from Sunabe down through Mihama, mapped as filled or formerly open water — the geological signature of exactly the reclamation this section describes.⁶¹¹

Where the fence has moved, as at Hamby, the change is total: a wartime and Cold War runway is now a grid of shopping streets and a public marina, a transformation the town itself presents as proof that returned base land can be redeveloped successfully — while making plain, in the same official accounting, how much more of Chatan has not yet followed it. The town today counts close to 29,000 residents on the minority of its land left outside base fences, a density that owes as much to the bases' continued presence as to the reclaimed land American Village stands on; next door, by its own account, Kadena town is left with even less room, its 15.12 square kilometers about 82 percent covered by the air base and an ammunition depot.^{310 15}

Timeline

13th-16th century	Chatan Gusuku is built and used as a regional stronghold of the Chuzan kingdom on the coastal ridge above Chatan. ¹¹
1577	The earliest known written reference to the place-name Chatan, according to the town's own history. ⁵
1605	Noguni Sokan, from the hamlet of Noguni in the Chatan magiri, brings the sweet potato from China; the kingdom formally commends his achievement in 1764. ¹
1649	A Satsuma-compiled map of the Ryukyu Kingdom labels the district "Kitatan magiri", the name that would evolve into "Chatan". ⁵
c. 1603	Nan'yo Shoko, a monk from Chatan's Tamayose hamlet remembered as "the Elder of Chatan", studies in mainland Japan. ²
1908	Okinawa's magiri-to-village reform turns Chatan's twelve hamlets into aza of the new Chatan village. ⁵
10 October 1944	US carrier aircraft raid Okinawa; 33 people are recorded killed in Chatan village. ¹³
1 April 1945	About 183,000 US troops land on the coast around Yomitan, Kadena and Chatan; the Japanese airfield inside Chatan falls the same day and the village's farmland is soon cleared for what becomes Kadena Air Base. ⁷¹³¹⁶
4 December 1948	Kadena, its access across the expanding airfield now barred, separates from Chatan village as its own municipality (population about 3,800). ⁹
1972	Okinawa reverts to Japan; about 65 percent of Chatan's area remains under US bases. ⁸
1980	Chatan gains formal town status. ⁸
1981	Hamby Airfield and the May-Moscarella firing range are returned to Chatan. ³⁸
1992-2004	The town adopts the American Village concept (1992) and builds it out on the former Hamby and newly reclaimed Mihama land, substantially complete by 2004. ³
2018	Town data put US base land at about 51.6 percent of Chatan's 13.91 square kilometers. ⁶
26 March 2021	Chatan Gusuku is designated a national Historic Site. ¹¹

Walking notes

Places to stand and look, in walking order. Straight-line distances only; check today's access and opening before you go.

- 1

Chatan Gusuku

北谷城跡

Climb the coastal ridge to see the castle's five walled enclosures, cut and roughly coursed limestone masonry, and the view along the coast the fortress once guarded; a national Historic Site since 2021.¹¹¹²

map
- 2

Site of the Chatan Tabukwa paddies

北谷ターブックワ

The low ground inland of the old village center once carried paddies ranked among Okinawa's three finest rice tracts; compare the aerial photographs in this dossier to see how completely base construction and later urban development erased them.⁵
- 3

Kadena Air Base perimeter

嘉手納飛行場フェンス

The fence line marks ground taken from Chatan and Kadena village farmland from 1945; the base's scale is best appreciated from a public vantage point along its edge rather than from the base itself.⁶⁹
- 4

Mihama American Village

美浜アメリカンビレッジ

Shops, cinemas and a Ferris wheel now stand on the returned Hamby Airfield and adjoining reclaimed land; look for the marina at Fishariina, a separate fishing-harbor project the town completed in the following decade.³

map
- 5

Sunabe seawall

砂辺海岸

The coast road and seawall north of American Village front another of the old magiri's twelve hamlets, Sunabe, today better known for its dive sites and its view of Kadena Air Base's runway lights after

dark.⁵

The stops today

Recent photographs of the stops, numbered as in the walking notes. Each was checked against the place the note describes; the line under the name says what it shows.



1. Chatan Gusuku

The wooded hill of the Chatan Gusuku site, seen from National Route 58

"Chatan Gusuku 01" by Bérangère444, CC BY 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons



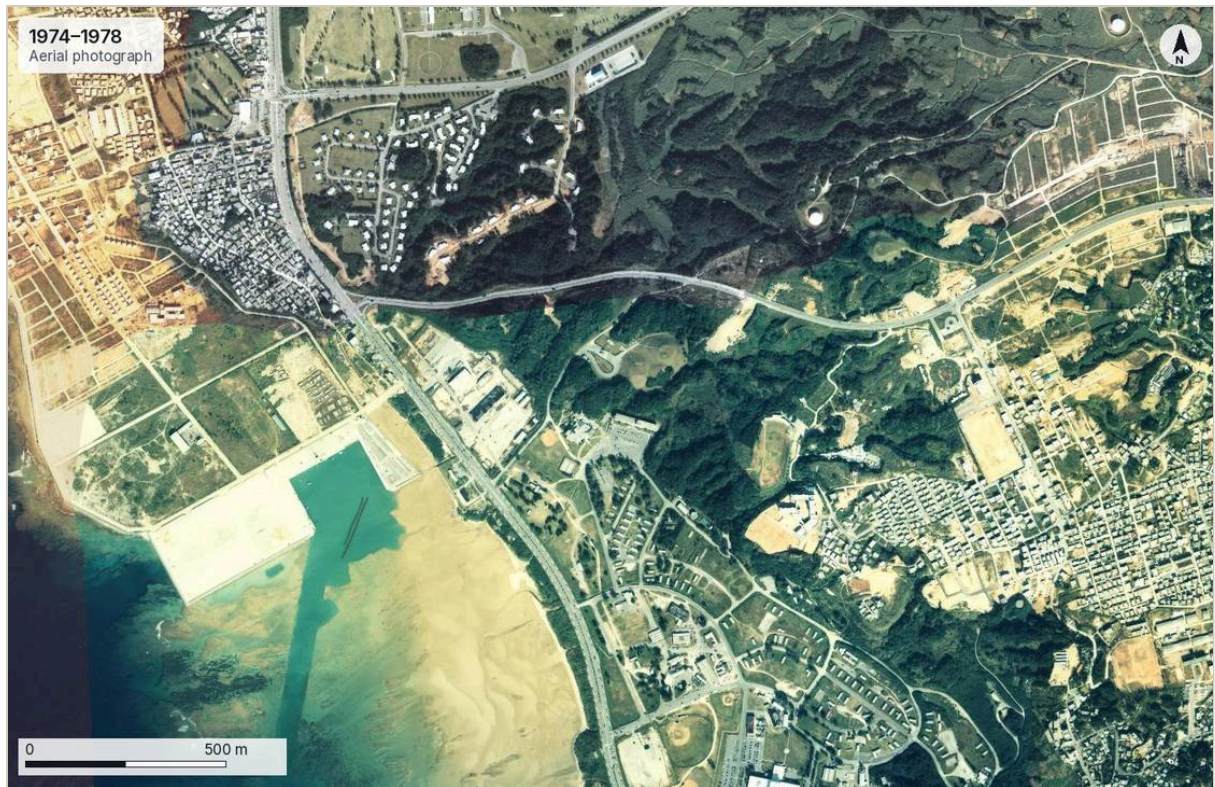
4. Mihama American Village

Overview of American Village with its shops and Ferris wheel (2007)

"Mihama AV D Japan" by Amoriver Information, CC BY-SA 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons

No picture for stops 2, 3, 5: no reusable photograph shows the place the note describes, and its position is not certain enough for an aerial view.

The same ground, 1974–1978 and 2023



1974–1978 aerial photograph — GSI Tiles *gazo1*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. North is up; the frame is identical in both images.



2023 annual orthophoto — GSI Tiles *nendophoto2023*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. Capture dates within a mosaic can differ from place to place.

How to compare. Anchor on features that rarely move — river banks, rail lines, shrine and temple grounds, main roads — then look for what changed around them. Differences in tone come from film, camera and season, not from the land itself.

Rivers, shorelines and terraces



Natural landforms as classified by GSI, over a recent aerial photograph in gray. Dark blue outlines mark former river channels.

 Mountain and hill slopes 35%	 Floodplain and coastal plain 19%
 Former water area 17%	 Plateaus and terraces 14%
 Sandbars and dunes 2.9%	 Foothill deposits 0.8%
 Water 0.5%	

What the main landforms mean

Mountain and hill slopes (35%). Ridges, valleys and fairly steep ground, including terrace-scarp slopes and volcanic ground. Heavy rain or earthquakes can trigger slope failures, debris flows and landslides.

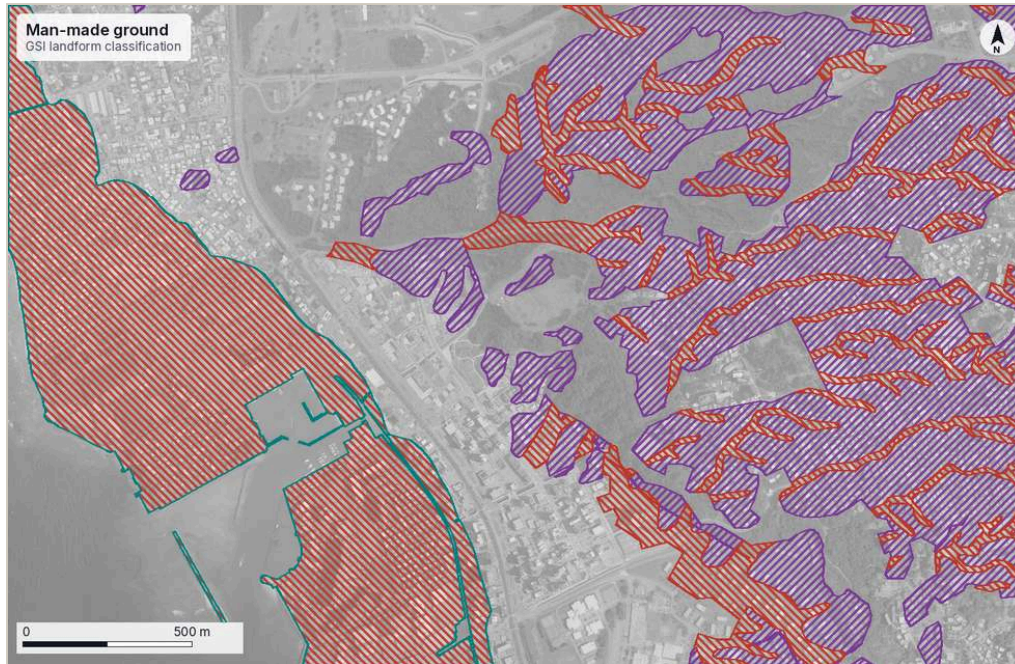
Floodplain and coastal plain (19%). Low, flat ground of little relief, built from sand and mud left by floods, or former seabed that emerged. River flooding. Ground is softer nearer the coast and shakes somewhat more; liquefaction tendency is strong on coastal plains and somewhat strong on floodplains. Storm surge near the coast.

Former water area (17%). Land shown by old maps and aerial photographs to have been sea, lake, pond, reservoir or river, later turned into land. Soft ground: very strong liquefaction tendency where filled, strong where drained. Storm surge near the coast.

Plateaus and terraces (14%). Flat ground standing in steps above its surroundings, left behind as the land around it was eroded. River flooding is rarely a threat unless the terrace is only slightly above the river; watch the slopes at its edges. Firm ground: shaking is relatively weak and liquefaction is unlikely.

Descriptions translated and condensed from GSI's landform-classification legend. They describe tendencies of each landform type, not the condition of any individual plot.

Fill, reclamation and the fields beneath the town



Hatching: man-made ground as classified by GSI. Teal outlines: former sea, river or pond. Dark blue outlines: former river channels.

Man-made ground

-  Cut ground 25%
-  Filled and reclaimed land 25%

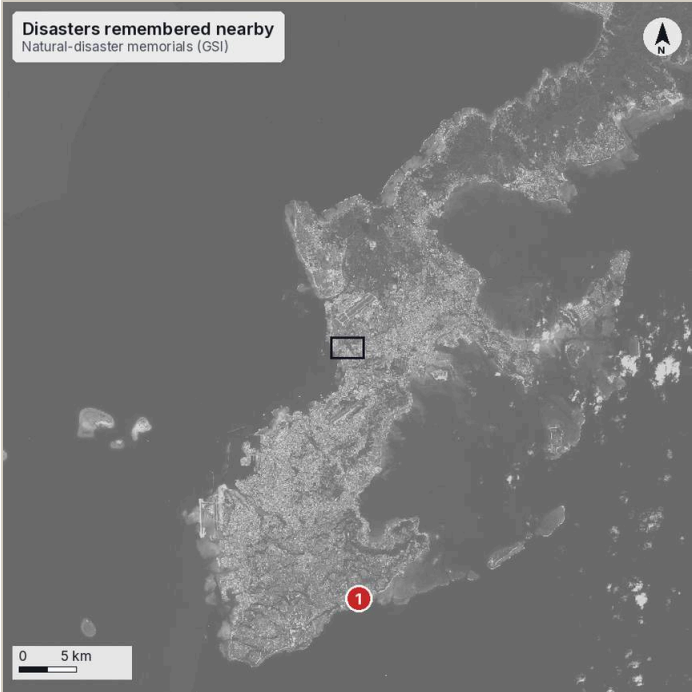
Cut ground (25%). Ground made by cutting into slopes of mountains or terrace edges. Depending on the cut slope, heavy rain or earthquakes may bring it down; the ground itself is generally firm.

Filled and reclaimed land (25%). Ground raised with fill, land made by dumping soil into the sea, rivers or ponds, or valleys filled in. May flood if not raised enough; on hills, rain or earthquakes can make the fill fail; in lowlands the liquefaction tendency is very strong, especially on filled sea, lake or river beds.

Meiji-era lowland

GSI has not traced Meiji-era lowland for this frame.

Memorials to natural disasters nearby



Numbered memorials; the black rectangle is the study area of this brief. Frame 60 km across.

Fewer than three memorials stand within 3 km of the study area, so the nearest ones within 30 km are listed.

Memorial	Disaster	Erected	Distance
1 Memorial tower to those lost at sea, prompted by Typhoon Iris of 1951 海上遭難者慰霊之塔	Typhoon Iris (9 May 1951) · storm surge / other	1956	21.9 km

What the memorials record

1. Memorial tower to those lost at sea, prompted by Typhoon Iris of 1951. On 9 May 1951 Typhoon Iris veered towards Okinawa Island and many fishing boats, warned of the storm only after sailing on the 8th, were lost; 41 of 55 people died. The Ou district built the tower in 1956 for those lost at sea and for safe voyages. It is surrounded by sea: take care in typhoons and storm surges.

Source: GSI Natural Disaster Memorials (自然災害伝承碑). English names and notes are Japan Time Atlas translations and summaries of GSI's Japanese descriptions; the memorials' own inscriptions may say more. "Erected" is the year GSI records for the monument.

Sources

1. 伊波普猷・眞境名安興 (Iha Fuyu and Majikina Ankou), 琉球之五偉人 [Five Great Men of Ryukyu], 1916; NDL frames 13, 14, 125, 171, 172, 174, 175, 176, 178. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/955204/1/171> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: Noguni Sokan's introduction of the sweet potato from China in 1605 (Keicho 10), his village origin, the 1764 commemoration of his achievement, and the book's own scholarly caveat about competing claims to precedence. Read as OCR snippets via the NDL full-text search API.
2. 島袋源一郎 (Shimabukuro Genichiro), 沖縄案内 [Guide to Okinawa], 1937; NDL frame 196. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/1908935/1/196> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: The monk Nan'yo Shoko of Chatan's Tamayose hamlet, known as "the Elder of Chatan", who studied in mainland Japan around 1603 and helped transmit mainland culture to the Ryukyu court. Read as an OCR snippet via the NDL full-text search API.
3. 北谷町総務部企画課 (Chatan Town Planning Division), 美浜タウンリゾート・アメリカンビレッジ完成報告書 [Completion report: Mihama Town Resort / American Village], 2004. https://www.chatan.jp/choseijoho/machi_keikaku/american.files/americanvillage.pdf (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)), checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The town's own 10-page completion report (Nov. 2004): the 1981 return of Hamby Airfield (42.5 ha) and the May-Moscarella firing range (22.9 ha) as the turning point ("prospects for the town's development opened wide"); the Kitamae (Hamby) land-readjustment district and the reclaimed Mihama district as one waterfront project; the construction timeline and site plan for Mihama American Village.
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7. 北谷町移動展 [Traveling exhibition: Chatan Town], 沖縄県公文書館 (Okinawa Prefectural Archives), 2016. https://www.archives.pref.okinawa.jp/event_information/past_exhibitions/925, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The 1948 separation of Kadena from Chatan village, the destruction of Chatan's residential areas after the April 1945 invasion and the construction of Kadena air base on former farmland, the 1947-51 Hawaii-based relief effort, 1951 hearings on military land, further emigration to Brazil/Peru/Bolivia in the 1950s-60s, and the 1970s tourism and landfill planning that produced the Mihama district.
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Further reading

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- 北谷町史 第6巻 (資料編5 北谷の戦後 1945-72) (北谷町史編集委員会編, 1988) — The occupation-era chapter of the town's own history, covering the Kadena split, land disputes and reconstruction in more detail than the archives exhibition summarised here. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/9776195> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))
- 嘉手納町史 資料編1・4・5 (嘉手納町史編さん委員会編, 1983-2000) — Kadena's own documentary town history, useful for the 1948 separation and the air base's postwar growth from the Kadena side. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/13254820> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))
- 上勢頭誌 上巻・中巻 (上勢頭誌編集委員会編, 1993/1997) — A hamlet-level history of Uwasedo (Chatan), useful for household-level detail on the pre-war rice-farming economy. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/13256069> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))

Where a Deep Research request would go next

- **Land records and maps for the pre-war "Chatan Tabukwa" paddies and the hamlets later absorbed into Kadena air base** — 沖縄県公文書館 (Okinawa Prefectural Archives), Naha, and 北谷町教育委員会 町史編集室 (Chatan Town Board of Education, Town History Compilation Office). Search the Archives' online catalogue for 北谷 and request pre-war cadastral maps (旧土地台帳); contact the town's history office for the 北谷町史 working papers.
- **Wartime and immediate postwar aerial photography of the Chatan-Kadena landing beaches and airfield construction** — US National Archives (NARA), College Park, Maryland (RG 127 US Marine Corps, RG 342 US Air Force imagery). Search the NARA catalog by place name (Chatan, Kadena) and date range April-December 1945; reproductions can be ordered remotely.
- **Individual and household experience of the 1948 administrative split from Kadena, including how families with land on both sides were affected** — 北谷町史 第6巻 and 嘉手納町史, and the Okinawa Prefectural Archives' oral-history holdings. Consult both towns' history offices; the Prefectural Archives' reference service (crd.ndl.go.jp-linked) can point to specific interview transcripts.
- **Detailed planning and negotiation records for the Hamby Airfield and May-Moscarella returns (1970s-1981) and the American Village project (1992-2004)** — 沖縄県公文書館 and 北谷町 都市計画課 (Chatan Town Urban Planning Division). Request the town's own planning-department archives and the prefectural archives' files on base-land negotiations for this period.
- **Archaeological reports on Chatan Gusuku and the wider gusuku network of central Okinawa** — 沖縄県立埋蔵文化財センター (Okinawa Prefectural Archaeological Center) and 北谷町教育委員会. Request excavation reports for Chatan Gusuku directly; several are also indexed in NDL Search under 北谷城.

Caveats

- Two official-adjacent sources give slightly different dimensions for Chatan Gusuku (about 165 m versus 30-100 m north-south); this dossier follows the Agency for Cultural Affairs' national designation record.
- The claim that Chatan Gusuku ranks among Okinawa's largest gusuku comes from the town's own tourism/heritage page alone and was not cross-checked against an independent ranking.
- Casualty figures here are limited to what an official Ministry of Internal Affairs and Communications record states for the 10 October 1944 raid (33 dead in Chatan); no verified figure for deaths in the 1 April 1945 landing itself was found in a source read for this dossier.

- Base land-share percentages are given exactly as reported for their own dates (65 percent in 1972, 68 percent for the mid-1970s planning era, about 51.6 percent as of town data current to 2018); a single fetch of a base-facilities page found in this session did not carry a more recent figure.
- The 1981 return of Hamby Airfield and the May-Moscarella firing range is given two different sizes in sources used here: the town's own 2004 completion report (42.5 ha and 22.9 ha) and a 2016 Okinawa Times retrospective (about 38 ha and about 25 ha, attributed to a named former town official's recollection). This dossier follows the town's own report as the more precise, contemporaneous figure.

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